

meaning that it's a portable trod. In the same way that digital information transfers in the blink of an eye, so too does this very idea make it possible to take the gateway wherever one goes.

Dangers on the road range from using computers to program digital blocks where the road is empty, to facing off against virus nervosa and monstrous chimera born out of the dark web. At the far end the trod connects to an entire freehold full of information that shadowy Kithain in the Autumn Realm would rather see forgotten. Due to the nature of where the trod ends, McSwiggan spends his time traveling in order to avoid fae who would like to destroy him and his gateway. Only members of his motley know how to access the digital highway, and convincing them to part with the information is not an easy task to undertake.

## The Shimmering Trails

Legends among the Kithain of coastal heritage speak of the Shimmering Trails. History describes the trod as taking on the appearance of a vast cavern system that connects fae to all manner of Silver Paths leading to ancient strongholds, laboratories, and even prisons.

While the trods remain lost for the moment, changelings have recovered clues on where the trod network's grand chamber is hidden. However, opening the gateway is complex, requiring the gate's opener to direct moonlight so far beneath the waters that it hits an ancient trio of statues, which portray merfolk and selkie nobles. Furthermore, it also requires the lifeblood of one of the merfolk (p. 448). Nonetheless, should everything be fulfilled, a pathway opens at the center of the area where the statues stand. Unfortunately, what remains of the legendary trods is a mystery to anyone discovering the trod network.

## Freeholds

Once upon a time, Faerie was everywhere. The worlds of flesh, spirit, and dream mingled freely, and the freeholds of the fae were numerous and conspicuous. As the dreams of humanity evolved, so too did freeholds, until enchanted forests and traveling camps became faerie towns and sprawling castles. During the Shattering, most of those places were lost, driven by Banality back into the Dreaming, or Mist-enshrouded so well even changelings forgot where they were.

The hardest of Faerie's sacred spaces survived, though they were sorely diminished. In the dark years of the Interregnum, changelings huddled around the guttering embers of once-powerful balefires. Many freeholds failed entirely in this period, drowned under the crushing waves of disbelief and exile. The few that remained were the only safe havens for faeries vulnerable to iron and Banality, until the development of the Changeling Way.

Ironically, the most powerful freeholds today were the weakest before the Shattering. Did their lack of power enable them to withstand the shifting world? Did Banality expend most of its strength abolishing the dolmen of kings and the rath-citadels of conquerors, leaving the smallest wellsprings untouched? Or was the trickle of remaining mortal superstition enough to sustain them?

The answer is impossible to learn, but most changelings don't care *why* a few freeholds survived when the majority were lost. They're just grateful they did.

## Living the Dream: The Nature of Freeholds

Freeholds are built around wellsprings protruding from the Dreaming into the mundane world, and are the backbone, heart, and soul of changeling society. For an individual changeling, freeholds are where he trades chimerical goods, embarks on quests, learns gossip, attends social and Court functions, or simply hangs out with his friends, safe from the ravages of the Autumn world.

Though almost all changelings consider their local freehold a home away from home, few actually dwell there permanently. Long-term residence has steep drawbacks. Time does not always pass at the same rate as in the outside world; a single night or several days spent inside the freehold may not affect the changeling, but longer than a week, and he risks Bedlam as he slowly disconnects from the Autumn world.

### Ownership

A changeling may gain a freehold in one of four ways: She can create it herself, inherit it from another, discover it by chance, or steal it from someone else. No matter how she acquires it, she must swear an oath to protect it and invest an amount of Glamour equal to the freehold's rating. Should the freehold ever be destroyed, she gains the freehold's level in Banality points. If she created the destroyed freehold, she also regains the Glamour she invested.

Freeholders are accorded certain rights and responsibilities, which are mystically enforced by the Dreaming:

- ⑤ **Harvest.** Only the owner of a freehold or another with her explicit permission may harvest Glamour from the balefire.
- ⑤ **Hospitality.** In accordance with the old laws of hospitality, the freeholder must offer food, drink and a night's hospitality to any who ask for it. She does not have to offer her balefire, however, and she does not have to offer more than one night.
- ⑤ **Sanctuary.** A changeling's freehold is her castle, and she can expect security within it. While inside her freehold, she gains the freehold's rating in extra dice to any defensive roll against physical or magical attacks, such as dodging, parrying, blocking, or countering, and gains half the freehold's rating to soak damage.
- ⑤ **Mandate.** Inside a freehold, the owner's word is law. Though she may be beholden to a higher lord or another freehold, within the bounds of her own freehold she sets the rules. Contravening a freeholder's rules inflicts a dice penalty equal to the freehold's rating for any action taken within the freehold, until the offense is forgiven by the freeholder.
- ⑤ **Passage.** A freeholder is also a guardian for a gate between worlds and, as such, is responsible for maintaining trods and raths. Though she does not have to allow travel through, few are willing to deny those on heroic quests.